

EPA Compliance Workshops Don't Reduce Violations

Lessons learned from "The effect of compliance assistance on pollution discharges and violations of environmental regulations" by Paul J. Ferraro & Jay P. Shimshack published in *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, (2026)

Offering polluters free help to follow environmental rules does not make them more likely to follow them. Researchers studied thousands of facilities that received EPA compliance workshops and found no reduction in violations — the program looked effective at first glance, but the improvement was a pre-existing trend, not caused by the workshops.

BACKGROUND

As the country shifts from one administration to the next, so does the EPA's approach to enforcing environmental rules. Some believe the best way to crack down on polluters is through inspections and penalties. Others want to help them comply, offering free **compliance assistance**: workshops, consulting, and technical support. Over the past ten years, the EPA has been reducing inspections and penalties in favor of compliance assistance. But that rests on the untested assumption that compliance assistance actually works. Researchers wanted to know if deregulation is a helpful tool, or an ineffective alternative.

WHY COMPLIANCE MATTERS

Environmental regulations from the EPA have played an important role in delivering clean air and clean water in the United States. However, these regulations are only effective if regulated entities comply with them. A central question is therefore not what rules to write, but how to encourage compliance.

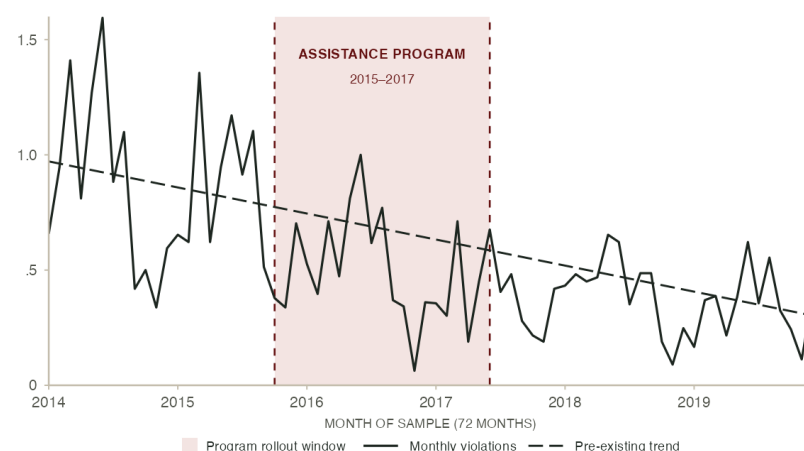
WHY EVALUATION MATTERS

There is a strong set of evidence supporting the effectiveness of inspections and penalties: they are proven to increase compliance. Comparable evidence for compliance assistance does not exist. Rather than relying on assumptions, the EPA has the data and tools at their disposal to better evaluate and compare their enforcement policies.

At first glance, compliance assistance looked like it reduced violations for assisted facilities by over 50%. When measured against facilities that turned down the same help, the program's **true effect was a precise zero** — the decline was already underway and unrelated to the workshops.

VIOLATIONS PER FACILITY, 2014–2019

Source: Ferraro & Shimshack (2026).



IMPLICATIONS

Funding

Given scarce funding for the EPA enforcement of-
fice, programs need to actually work. This study
indicates **compliance assistance may not be as
effective as previously thought.**

Alternatives

The **trade-offs of different policies should be
weighed as the EPA plans future programs.** As-
sistance is not proven to be as effective as inspec-
tions, though that is not to say they'll never be
effective.

Oversight

The EPA does not systematically collect data on
compliance assistance activities, according to a
2020 report from the Government Accountability
Office, and **this study underscores the need for
more deliberate program evaluation.**